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Perception and Thought: Existentialism in Context

I struggled with generating an authentic decision for the longest time, as the way I see it authenticity is invalidated by a multitude of external historical and societal pressures; similar to how Beauvoir and Fanon identify discrimination as historically constructed (facticity and the "impossible ontology"), the factors embedded within the blanket of society, create pressures on humans and define their existence. Even though the negation of this fact (like Heidegger's Dasein (human existence) "being towards death") contributes to our perceived freedom. This was the overarching dilemma I encountered and grappled with, which in this writing I will outline through my views accompanied by art representing the text and ideals of existentialist thinkers.



John Atkinson Grimshaw, *Reflection on the Thames, Westminster, London*. 1880.

Nevertheless I made a decision, in order to satisfy this assignment; on a Saturday afternoon at the rowing team alumni social dinner in the Grand Ballroom of the student center, dressed to the nines, I gazed. Being drawn to the balcony outside from where I could look upon the street below. I decided to stare intently, not at a single object but the cityscape before me as a whole, a street, littered with dynamic elements of moving people and vehicles clashing with the stagnant backdrop of concrete and streetlights. However, the inherited context of the situation cannot be ignored behind me I heard chatter, and the sound of finger food moving from platter to plate; as much as I had a reason to congregate and talk (which could not be ignored) I returned to the balcony to perceive the happenings of the street below. What I felt is embodied within the painting below (Grimshaw). The Wanderlust shown within the woman looking out onto the Thames and the barges below or the dog onto the street towards the taller humans walking by. I was an observer of a single scene, looking past the happenings on the street but perceiving them, nonetheless.



Edvard Munch, *Evening on Karl Johan Street*. 1892

In the *Myth of Sisyphus* Camus, when not referencing suicide, touches on the very scenario which I experienced, and my hesitations to authenticity outlined above (to which Camus in short states “Man is always prey to his truths” (par. 3).). The choice to notice the mundane and

act of my own volition, occurs out of an inability or despair which Camus references through Jaspers "[The Absurd] and that inability to understand becomes the existence that illuminates everything" (par. 5). Through the lens of Camus this embrace of the absurd occurred through an universal immaturity found within humans that forces us to place meaning onto the world, it is through the recognition of the forced meaning that we recognize the absurd and become the 'Absurd Man'. As this Absurd Man one can recognize the struggle of existence, while applying reason and context towards existence without ruling out the irrational by which we "… [embrace] in a single glance all the data of experience…" (par. 10). It is important to note his reference to a glance, this displays the authenticity of my decision and action embracing the act of being the Absurd Man by reasoning through the existence of the irrational ("… if I recognize the limits of reason, I do not therefore negate it…" (par. 14).). The painter Edvard Munch also embraces being the absurd man in his 1892 painting *Evening on Karl Johan Street*, displaying the same decision and action as I did for this assignment, he viewed a street; but he depicted his findings within his easel. His embrace of the absurd is shown in the large crowd depicted, their forms human, but their faces aghast or empty without emotion; displaying both that the struggle is experienced within humans but in reality projected from the observer onto others. By recognizing this lack of meaning in the world we end up "… finding a meaning and depth in it" (par. 17). It is through perception that we are able to confront the absurd, accept the irrational, and negate our existential dread as "Only at the end of this difficult path does the absurd man recognize his true motives" (par. 26). Camus presents the strongest support for this idea and my authentic decision through the following paragraph:

> "[The] Consciousness illuminates it by paying attention to it. Consciousness does not form the object of its understanding, it merely focuses, it is the act of attention… it

> resembles the projector that suddenly focuses on an image. The difference is that there is no scenario, but a successive and incoherent illustration. In that magic lantern all the pictures are privileged. Consciousness suspends in experience the objects of its attention. Through its miracle it isolates them. Henceforth they are beyond all judgments. This is the "intention" that characterizes consciousness" (par. 18)

He categorizes the consciousness, or methods of thought, into two aspects: the "psychological" and the "metaphysical". The psychological itself is presented as the absurd spirit, where reality is "…drained instead of … explained" (par. 19). This "essence" is just perception represented in the general thoughts of man, leading to the incomprehensibility of the absurd. The "metaphysical" on the other hand is considered by Camus as "privileged essence" were everything and every thought is equivalent; returning depth of understanding of the universe, as if through billions of equivalent atoms. Camus' relevant discussion of suicide begins here, although I personally don't fully align myself with his view, his key highlight regarding the possibility of death at one's own hands he determines that "… [This negation of] one of the terms of the opposition on which he lives amounts to escaping it" to which he refers back to part of my authentic decision that (in terms of suicide) "Keeping it alive is, above all, contemplating it" ("Absurd Freedom" par. 31). Through this Camus places the act of perception and contemplation into realizing and negating our role in our own existence, framing my act as authentic. He continues to provide a framework for my previous objections as well "[through imagined purpose] he adapted himself to the demands of purpose to be achieved and became a slave of his own liberty" (par. 38). through this and the societal and historical pressures I outlined above "… the absurd man realizes that he was not really free" (par. 38). But by recognizing and

negating these facts we are able to confront the absurd just as Munch, Sisyphus, and Camus himself have.

Nietzche posits in *The Genealogy of Morals* referring to his ascetic ideal that "… [man] will sooner will nothingness than not will at all" (Nietzche 121). This is done by two modes as a reactive ascetic used by the as a narcotic, and an active form used by philosophers as a tool for power. He might reject my gaze as the former reactive asceticism, in a means to find a state of "nothingness" (which was not my intention) or escape the pain of existence, Nietzche would diagnose it as a symptom of nihilism. This is a described "self-hypnotism" which causes "The alleviation consists in the attention of the sufferer being absolutely diverted from suffering" (175). Acting as a "…mechanically desired narcotic against pain of any kind." (164). Ultimately, he affirms the reactive ascetic as the final stage of nihilism. As the act was a deliberate choice by my sovereign spirit to create the conditions for the paper, to intellectually find the limits of my perception. For the 'philosopher' the ascetic practice of solitude and deep focus are nor denials of life but affirmation of one's own power. Nietzche posits that the philosopher smiles toward the ascetic ideal because he views it as an "optimum of the conditions of the highest and boldest intellectuality" (136). Instead of falling into the nihilistic existential dread, my act can be "… joyous asceticism of a deified and newly fledged animal, sweeping over life rather than resting" (137). Staring out onto the street would be the philosopher's pondering ground, a "desert", providing "… a deliberate obscurity; a getting-out-of the way of one's self; a fear of noise, admiration, papers, influence; a little office, a daily task, something that hides rather than brings to light…" (138). Nietzche further establishes that there is no "neutral" subject whi chooses to act; but rather that the "doer" is a concept created by language. He states "… there is no "being" behind doing, working, becoming; "the doer" is a mere appanage to the action. The action is

everything" (46). To establish who wills the action Nietzche tells us that only the "sovereign individual" who has "got loose from the morality of custom" possesses a "genuine consciousness of power and freedom" (64). For this sovereign, my decision, is a free action as it is a true expression of unbreakable will and "…mastery over himself…" (64). as my action was a product of "personal, long, and independent will" (64). To act for my own volition instead of a "masquerade" of philosophical thought, Nietzche roughly supports my authentic decision as genuine.



James Abbott McNeill Whistler, *Nocturne in Grey and Gold: Chelsea Snow*. 1876.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* introduces a phenomenological approach toward the dilemma and act of perception. He proposes that the human gaze, in which I engaged by looking at the objective street, is in duality both "…to plunge oneself into it…" (78). and "… inhabit it…" (79). Placing my gaze onto the street was not the passive reception of data but a focused act of attention where "… I become anchored in it…" (78). In this inhabitation I was able to perceive the cityscape and understand the "… aspect which they present to [my habitation]" (79). Through perception alone I was able to essentially become one with the

horizon. By proving my focus onto the city I had to make the active choice to "…put the surroundings in abeyance…" (78). To gain better perception of the objective, by blocking out the background or removing my eyes' 'wanderlust' to focus on the same tableau, the objective I perceived provided me with more value and meaning as I observed it, this was my perception "… open[ing] the object" (78). By my active gaze and negation of objective thought I refuse to crystalize a static perception of the world. This lack of objective thought ensures that we do not "lose contact with perpetual experience" (82). Marleau-Ponty warns that the "absolute positing of a single object is the death of consciousness…" (82). As it freezes existence and our perception of it into a "crystallized" state, but by refusing to "posit" an object in my perception, the subject remains something that I am able to inherit, maintaining a fluid connection. The blank contemplation becomes a way to experience the total eternal nature of existence. "If I contemplate the house attentively and with no thought in mind, it has something eternal about it…" (79). This state allows our inner sense to make sense of our perception before outside factors of language or labels effect our world-view (both psychological and metaphysical), this is the act of *ek-stase* or active transcendence (81). Where we as the viewer go beyond our experience to find and define the absolute object. Through the action of perception I am able to recognize the truth in the subjective and objective presented by my eyes aiding in the authenticity of my actions.

My decision to perceive the world intentionally, not through a blank stare or over-intent focus, through the power of acceptance and negation, I am able to form my act as genuine. Although the perception varies by philosopher (and artist), from Camus' Absurd represented in Munch, my feelings around what I saw represented by Grimshaw, or the recognition of the ascetic and the objective found within Whistler's 1876 painting, *Nocturne in Grey and Gold:*

Chelsea Snow. Our authenticity and perception is plagued by factors outside of human control or understanding through our acceptance and negation of these facts humans are able to will their own power and confront the absurdity of our existence, it is through this which we generate authentic actions, or actions we deem as authentic (as a result of our negation). Which is what truly matters when considering over our own matters of mind and body in the historical and social context of this absurd world.

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